Call Prep: Austin Ledesma / Solace

Monday, August 10, 2026 • 3:30 PM CT • Microsoft Teams

Context in 60 Seconds

First structured sync following the July 29 lunch + onsite. Austin sent a full recap that day, the combined deck August 3, and Entergy/Texans follow-up August 5. Relationship has momentum. The single most important thing to resolve today: **who owns what, and what happens first.** The account list is agreed. The execution is not.

Account Map (Austin's July 29 Recap)

Status	Accounts
Joint-owned	Schwab
Joint targets	CBRE, Texas Stock Exchange, S&P Global (TBD), Caterpillar, Entergy, PepsiCo, Toyota
Solace-only	AT&T, Halliburton, ExxonMobil, Builders FirstSource, Toyota Material Handling
Improving-only	NRG, 7-Eleven, American Airlines (paper only), Southwest (paper only), McKesson, Chevron

Note on Halliburton: Kyle Scott and Ryan Piper own the PS conversation — not Austin. Defer to them if it comes up.

Open Issues to Resolve

1. CBRE — Reconcile the "Joint Target" Framing

Issue: Austin listed CBRE as a joint target. This is not a cold prospect for Improving.

Improving's actual CBRE position:

- 9-year relationship. Active PSA. Rod Patane owns it — active pursuit.
- Three key stakeholders already engaged: **Rama** (Chief Architect), **Parsa** (Director of Platform), **Prasanna** (VP Software Engineering). Rob Ogbah reset 1:1s with all three in March 2026.
- Technical deep dives in track: leads **Venu, Vishwak, Bavia** + others.
- Rob Ogbah (Microsoft) has an **active Confluent referral** at CBRE — Microsoft-Improving-Confluent stack play already in motion.
- Scott McMichael 1:1 notes (Feb 2026): "Confluent/CBRE — Next Tues." Tim Rayburn notes (March 2026): "CBRE — Flink."

What to establish:

- Austin almost certainly doesn't know Improving's depth here.
- What Solace use case is he pursuing, and does it touch Rama/Parsa/Prasanna?
- Frame it as "we should coordinate" not "joint target." Solace's EDA story is additive to the Confluent/Flink work.

Your position: CBRE is an active Improving account. Any Solace play coordinates through Rod and you. This is an asset — use it to accelerate Solace's entry rather than letting him go in cold.

2. Schwab — Define "Joint-Owned" Operationally

Improving's current position: Derek Nwamadi owns it. Flagged as going cold — the June update showed positive meetings but no visible progress. Latest CRM entry (July 24): $0 backfill Instructional Designer. Active but shallow — not a strategic partnership anchor.

What to establish:

- What does Solace actually have at Schwab? Active deployment, live relationship, or just a name on a slide?
- If Solace has real presence, this could flip — Solace-led account where Improving supports.
- Define "joint-owned" operationally: who leads, who supports, how credit is shared?
- Don't leave this as a vague agreement. Either there's a specific play or there isn't.

3. American Airlines — Where Does This Stand?

The thread:

- July 29: Austin pitched AA as "Kitty Hawk." Cited July 28 FAA ground stop. Referenced United Airlines case study (4-hour outage recovery improvement, 6B events/day). Asked if Diana could intro AA's Managing Director of Customer Loyalty.
- Aug 5: You told Austin you'd check on Misty at AA. Austin acknowledged, offered to help re-engage.

What to establish:

- Did Diana engage? What did she say about Misty / the Customer Loyalty MD?
- Is AA a viable first target or still "paper only"?
- If Diana is ready: what's the ask — joint meeting, warm email, or just a name?
- If Diana is not ready: set a realistic timeline rather than leaving it open.

Austin's hook is strong. If Diana can open the door, pursue it.

4. Entergy — Andrew Freson Just Left, Contacts Need Updating

Critical development: Andrew Freson, your primary Entergy contact, has left the company. The contact map needs to be rebuilt.

Improving's Entergy context (April SKO):

- Energy hyperscaler: $10B/year capex x4 years; data center deals with Meta and Google driving tech investment.
- **Primary target: SAP Analytics Cloud (SAC) RFP** — introduced to 11 finance contacts. MSA in place via Clearly Agile (being acquired). Client dissatisfied with incumbent Accenture.
- **Stephen Johnson** (Houston) is the internal SME for energy sector. **Devlin** is the industry knowledge resource.
- **SKO strategy:** Land SAP deal, then pitch AI DLP solution. Build dedicated Entergy account plan.
- Rod Patane's action item: connect John Pilch to schedule Entergy CTO Jason meeting.

What to establish:

- Share with Austin that Freson left — he may not know, and it affects his contacts too.
- Austin's contacts (Mark Bonfiglio, Krishna Priya): tech side or business/finance side? Connect to SAP RFP track?
- Can Solace's EDA play bundle into the SAP conversation — Improving's current entry point?
- Coordinate the contact map rebuild — don't run parallel tracks.

5. Cadence — Lock It In

Austin's proposal: Bi-weekly or monthly 30-min standing sync. **Recommendation: bi-weekly.** Monthly is too slow for a partnership this early. Keep Confluent as a separate track.

What to lock today:

- Frequency: bi-weekly vs. monthly
- Format: just you and Austin, or bring in Kyle/Ryan?
- First meeting agenda: account round-robin or focus-account-per-sprint model?
- Confirm Confluent stays its own track.

6. Texans Suite — September 20, Texans vs. Bengals

Status: Suite lease fully executed. DocuSign completed August 7. Drayton McMichael (Membership Services Advisor) confirmed this morning. AP is being set up for payment.

What's included:

- 22 tickets + 8 parking passes
- VIP entry + 300-level club lounge access
- Catering optional: est. $1,500–$3,000 additional (or use 300-level lounge concessions)
- Sideline passes: TBD — Drayton checks 2 weeks out. Optimistic but can't promise.
- Hotel recs: JW Marriott, Hilton on Post Oak, Westin Galleria

Cost summary: Suite lease ~$25,000. Catering adds $1,500–$3,000. All-in: ~$26,500–$28,000.

Note: Stephen Johnson (Improving Houston) is also attending separately — Drayton confirmed he reached out independently.

What to establish with Austin:

- Is Solace in? How many people on his side?
- Joint-account contacts worth inviting to turn this into a sourcing event?
- When do you need final headcount?

7. Remaining Joint Targets — Quick Round-Robin

No deep dives needed — a quick status check on each signals you're taking the list seriously:

- **Texas Stock Exchange** — nascent exchange, EDA natural fit. Who leads?
- **S&P Global** — marked TBD. Real target or aspirational?
- **Caterpillar** — any current Solace or Improving presence?
- **PepsiCo** — same question
- **Toyota** (joint target, vs. Toyota Material Handling which is Solace-only) — what's the differentiation?

The Combined Deck (August 3)

Austin sent the Solace + Improving OnSite deck August 3. Slides 4–21: Solace 101. Slides 22–29: Customer proof points. Slides 30+: Vertical and account alignment. At minimum, review Slides 30+ before the call.

Suggested Agenda (30–45 min)

Time	Topic
5 min	Quick wins since the onsite — Entergy debrief, AA status update
10 min	Cadence: lock format, frequency, first meeting date

10 min	CBRE and Schwab — reconcile account framing
10 min	Near-term plays: AA intro path, Entergy next steps
5 min	Texans suite logistics

Key Signals to Watch

- **CBRE reaction:** If Austin is surprised you're already there, that's a data point about his prep.
- **Schwab concreteness:** Logo on a slide, or a real play? Same test.
- **AA urgency:** He's clearly excited. If Diana isn't ready, manage expectations — don't let it float another two weeks.
- **Austin's style:** Natural relationship builder — the Texans game, the detailed recap, the United case study. He's invested. Match his energy and give him something concrete on each account.

Solace Team — FYI (on email thread, not on today's call)

- **Ryan Piper** — cited on Halliburton PS conversation
- **Kyle Scott** — same
- **Michael Hilmen** — sent the combined deck with Austin
- **Laurent Guillot** — CC only, no specific role noted

Prepared by Jarvis — 2026-08-10